

MC 3505: Media and Policy Processes

Prof. Catherine Chen, Ph.D.

Spring 2026

E-mail: catherinechen@lsu.edu

Web: <https://moodle.lsu.edu/course/view.php?id=68435>

Office Hours: T 3 - 5 pm or by appt

Class Hours: T/Th Noon - 1:20 pm

Office: Hodges 255

Classroom: Coates 109

Course Description

This course examines how media systems shape political decision-making and policy processes in the United States. The course focuses on media as an institutional actor that structures political attention, participation, and governance. Students will study how issues enter the policy agenda, how they are framed and debated, and how different actors including journalists, citizens, platforms, and government institutions interact in the policymaking process.

Materials

Course materials are available on Moodle. All students officially registered for the course can access the course's Moodle page. The Moodle page includes a course syllabus, announcements, readings, assignments, lecture slides, and any other relevant course information. Lecture slides will be posted after each week's lectures. It is each student's responsibility to regularly monitor Moodle and their email for course-related communication. Claims of not seeing relevant information will not be accepted as a justification for missed work or deadlines.

Course Goals

Upon completion of this course, students should be able to:

- Explain how media systems shape policymaking in the United States, including how issues gain attention, are framed, and move through political institutions.
- Identify key actors in media and policy processes, including journalists, platforms, social movements, government agencies, and elected officials, and describe their roles and incentives.
- Distinguish among major media effects relevant to policymaking, such as agenda-setting, framing, and amplification, and explain how these processes influence political outcomes.

- Describe how citizens and organized groups participate in policymaking, including formal mechanisms (e.g., public comments, testimony) and informal mechanisms (e.g., protest, mobilization), and evaluate the limits of participation.
- Analyze how changes in media technologies alter policy challenges, from broadcast regulation to digital platforms, algorithms, and generative artificial intelligence.
- Explain why governing modern media systems is difficult, focusing on issues of platform governance, surveillance capitalism, privacy and data protection, enforcement capacity, and accountability.
- Evaluate the tradeoffs involved in media-related policy interventions, including tensions between innovation, democratic accountability, economic incentives, and regulation.
- Apply course concepts to contemporary policy debates, using real-world examples to assess how media shape political processes and democratic governance.

Course Schedule

The schedule is tentative and subject to change. If, as you look over the course schedule, you do not see an issue you would like me to cover, please let me know. I will try my best to incorporate that topic, approach, article, issue, etc. into our class. The goal is to help you uncover interesting ideas and topics in media and policymaking research and practice. I encourage you to ask questions, bring in outside material, and dive deeply into the course materials.

Week 01, 01/12 - 01/16: Course intro: Media and the Public Sphere

Required Readings:

1. Syllabus
2. Habermas, J. (2006). Political communication in media society: Does democracy still enjoy an epistemic dimension? The impact of normative theory on empirical research. *Communication Theory*, 16(4), 411-426.

Week 02, 01/19 - 01/23: Agenda-Setting

Required Readings:

1. McCombs, M. (2005). A look at agenda-setting: Past, present and future. *Journalism Studies*, 6(4), 543-557.
2. Vu, H. T., Guo, L., & McCombs, M. E. (2014). Exploring "the world outside and the pictures in our heads": A network agenda-setting study. *Journalism & Mass Communication Quarterly*, 91(4), 669-686.
3. Carpenter, D. (2023). Agenda democracy. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 26(1), 193-212.

Week 03, 01/26 - 01/30: Framing

Required Readings:

1. Gubitz, S. R., Klar, S., Robison, J., & Druckman, J. N. (2018). Political dynamics of framing. In T. N. Ridout (Ed.), *New Directions in Media and Politics* (2nd ed., pp. 29–53). Routledge.
2. Iyengar, S. (1996). Framing responsibility for political issues. *The Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, 546(1), 59-70.
3. Stroud, N. J., & Muddiman, A. (2019). Social media engagement with strategy-and issue-framed political news. *Journal of Communication*, 69(5), 443-466.

Week 04, 02/02 - 02/06: Social Media Affordances

Required Readings:

1. boyd, d. (2010). Social network sites as networked publics: Affordances, dynamics, and implications. In Z. Papacharissi (Ed.), *Networked self: Identity, community, and culture on social network sites* (pp. 39–58). Routledge.

Quiz 1 in class on Thursday

Week 05, 02/09 - 02/13: Role of Journalism

Required Readings:

1. Bennett, W. L. (2016). *News: The Politics of Illusion*. University of Chicago Press. Chapters 1 and 2.
2. Mancini, P. (2013). Media fragmentation, party system, and democracy. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 18(1), 43-60.
3. Mazzoleni, G., & Schulz, W. (1999). "Mediatization" of politics: A challenge for democracy? *Political Communication*, 16(3), 247-261.

RitW1 due at 11:59 pm on Monday

Week 06, 02/16 - 02/20: Actors in Public Policy

No class on Tuesday in observance of Mardi Gras

Required Readings:

1. Knutson, K. (2023). *An Introduction to U.S. Public Policy: Theory and Practice*. Pressbooks. Chapter 2.
2. Kingdon, J. W. (2014). *Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies*. Pearson. Chapters 2 and 3.

Week 07, 02/23 - 02/27: How is Policy Made?

Required Readings:

1. Knutson, K. (2023). *An Introduction to U.S. Public Policy: Theory and Practice*. Pressbooks. Chapter 4.
2. Kingdon, J. W. (2014). *Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies*. Pearson. Chapter 4.

Week 08, 03/02 - 03/06: Participatory Mechanisms in Policymaking

Required Readings:

1. Stuessy, M. M. (2023). Access to Government Information: An Overview.
<https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/R47058>
2. United States Environmental Protection Agency. (2025). Public Participation Guide: Introduction to Public Participation.
<https://www.epa.gov/international-cooperation/public-participation-guide-introduction-public-participation>

Week 09, 03/09 - 03/13: Spring break, no class

Week 10, 03/16 - 03/20: Social movement and mobilization

Required Readings:

1. Bennett, W. L., & Segerberg, A. (2012). The logic of connective action: The personalization of contentious politics. *Information, Communication & Society*, 15(5), 739–768.
2. Milan, S. (2015). When algorithms shape collective action: Social media and the dynamics of cloud protesting. *Social Media+ Society*, 1(2), 2056305115622481.
3. Tufekci, Z. (2017). *Twitter and Tear Gas. The Power and Fragility of Networked Protest*. Yale University Press. Chapter 5

Quiz 2 in class on Thursday

Week 11, 03/23 - 03/27: Surveillance Capitalism

Required Readings:

1. Zuboff, S. (2023). The age of surveillance capitalism. In W. Longhofer & D. Winchester (Eds.), *Social theory re-wired: New connections to classical and contemporary perspectives* (3rd ed., pp. 203–213). Routledge
2. Kavenna, J. (2019). Shoshana Zuboff: Surveillance capitalism is an assault on human autonomy.
<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2019/oct/04/shoshana-zuboff-surveillance-capitalism-assault-human-automomy-digital-privacy>
3. Zhang, Y. (2023). Three Moral Challenges of Surveillance Capitalism in the Metaverse. *International Journal of Law, Ethics, and Technology*, 1, 64-87.

RitW2 due at 11:59 pm on Monday

Week 12, 03/30 - 04/03: Media Regulation

Required Readings:

1. Ronald Reagan Presidential Library and Museum (2025). *Fairness Doctrine*.
<https://www.reaganlibrary.gov/archives/topic-guide/fairness-doctrine>
2. Fagan, F. (2017). Systemic social media regulation. *Duke Law and Technology Review*, 16, 393-439.
3. Gillespie, T. (2018). *Custodians of the Internet: Platforms, Content Moderation, and the Hidden Decisions That Shape Social Media*. Yale University Press. Chapter 2.

Week 13, 04/06 - 04/10: Privacy and Data Protection

Required Readings:

1. Salas, P. (2025). The Myth of Consent in the Digital Age.
<https://www.fulr.org/post/the-myth-of-consent-in-the-digital-age>
2. Beens, R. E. G. (2020). The Privacy Mindset Of The EU Vs. The US.
<https://www.forbes.com/councils/forbestechcouncil/2020/07/29/the-privacy-mindset-of-the-eu-vs-the-us/>
3. Bologa, A. (2023). Fifty Shades of GDPR Privacy: The Good, the Bad, and the Enforcement.
<https://cepa.org/article/fifty-shades-of-gdpr-privacy-the-good-the-bad-and-the-enforcement/>

Week 14, 04/13 - 04/17: Algorithms as Governance Tools

Required Readings:

1. Winner, L. (1980). Do artifacts have politics? *Daedalus*, 109(1), 121-136.
2. Gritsenko, D., & Wood, M. (2022). Algorithmic governance: A modes of governance approach. *Regulation & Governance*, 16(1), 45-62.
3. Judge, B., Nitzberg, M., & Russell, S. (2025). When code isn't law: rethinking regulation for artificial intelligence. *Policy and Society*, 44(1), 85-97.

Week 15, 04/20 - 04/24: Guest Lecture & Quiz 3

Guest Lecture by Prof. Yunwen Wang, Assistant Professor at the William Allen White School of Journalism and Mass Communications at the University of Kansas

Quiz 3 in class on Thursday

Week 16, 04/27 - 05/01: Generative AI & Policymaking

Required Readings:

1. Pachipala, S. (2024). Generative AI and Democracy: Rebooting Trust, Bit by Bit.
<https://computing.mit.edu/wp-content/uploads/2024/06/Generative-AI-and-Democracy.pdf>

RitW3 due at 11:59 pm on Monday

Assessments

RitW Assignments

In this course, students will engage in a series of “Research in the Wild” (RitW) assignments that apply course concepts to real-world media and policy processes. Rather than focusing on personal opinions or abstract theory, these assignments ask students to analyze how media systems, institutions, and technologies shape policymaking in practice. The RitW assignments are designed to help students connect course readings and lectures to contemporary political and media environments, developing a structured understanding of how media influence policymaking through visibility, governance, and institutional power. Detailed prompts and rubrics for each assignment will be posted on Moodle no later than 10 days before the assignment is due. Each essay should be approximately 3-4 pages in length, double-spaced, with 12-point font and 1-inch margins.

Quizzes

There will be three in-class open-book quizzes. You can refer to your notes or slides, but you cannot refer to search engine or AI assistants. Each quiz will cover only the content introduced between two quizzes, meaning the quizzes are not cumulative. Each quiz will consist of approximately 25 multiple-choice questions and one short answer, and you will have 45 minutes to complete it. Attendance in the classroom during the quiz time is required. There is no additional lecture on quiz day. If a student needs to attend a quiz remotely, they must make arrangements at least 24 hours prior to the scheduled quiz. Failure to do so may result in Professor Chen denying the request, in which case the quiz will be marked as a zero. In the event of technical difficulties during the quiz, you may request a second attempt at the discretion of Professor Chen.

Final Exam

The final exam will assess your understanding of the key concepts, theories, and discussions covered throughout the course. It will consist of the following components:

- 25 Multiple Choice Questions (2 points each): These questions will test your knowledge of the course material, requiring you to select the most appropriate answer from the given options.
- 2 Short Answer Questions (15 points each): These questions will require you to provide concise, yet thorough, responses that demonstrate your ability to apply and analyze course concepts.
- 1 Long Answer Question (20 points): This question will require a more in-depth response, where you will be expected to synthesize information from multiple topics covered in the course to construct a well-argued and comprehensive answer.

Please note: The final exam is closed-book, meaning you will not be allowed to refer to any textbooks, notes, or other materials during the exam. Be sure to prepare accordingly to ensure you can confidently recall and apply what you have learned.

Participation

This class does not take formal attendance, but there will be light in-class tasks (polls, reflections, or quick responses) that count toward participation. Regular class attendance is expected and should not depend on whether a particular class session includes participation credit. Not every class session will include graded activities. Course content, discussion, and explanations provided in class are essential for understanding the material and succeeding in the course, regardless of whether participation points are assigned on a given day.

Supportive Classroom Environment

We will at times be discussing challenging material. Students should be ready to create a classroom climate that is consciously different from the contemporary political and media environment. This means granting each other the assumption of good intentions and being willing to share and receive tentative and provisional ideas, impressions, in class discussions. To create a classroom environment that supports respectful, critical inquiry, the following principles will guide our work:

- Bring light, not heat: Treat every member of the class with respect, even if you disagree with their opinion.
- Remember that reasonable minds can differ on any number of perspectives, opinions, and conclusions.
- Expect and celebrate constructive disagreement because it sharpens thinking, deepens understanding, and reveals novel insights.
- Expect and celebrate constructive disagreement because it sharpens thinking, deepens understanding, and reveals novel insights.
- Try to make no assumptions about the views of others in the classroom.
- You will not be graded on your opinions.

Grading Policy

Evaluation in this course is based on a combination of 3 research assignments, 3 quizzes, a final exam, plus class participation.

- Research in the Wild Assignments x 3, 10% each = 30%
- Quizzes x 3, 10% each = 30%
- Final Exam 30%
- Class participation 10%

A's are reserved for excellent & exceptional work, B's suggest your work is very good, C's are for satisfactory work.

96.5 and above A+	76.50–79.99 C+
93.50 – 96.49 A	73.50–76.49 C
90.00–93.49 A-	70.00–73.49 C-
86.50–89.99 B+	66.50–69.99 D+
83.50–86.49 B	63.50–66.49 D
80.00–83.49 B-	63.50–66.49 D
	59.99 and below F

Course Policies

During Class

I understand that some of you would like to take notes electronically so computers will be allowed in class. Please refrain from using computers for anything but activities related to the class. Off-task use of phones, laptops, or tablets may result in a reduction of participation credit. Eating and drinking are allowed in class but please refrain from it affecting the course. Don't eat your lunch in class as the classes are typically active.

Attendance Policy

Attendance is expected in all lectures. Valid excuses for absence with proof will be accepted only **before** class. If students reached out after a class regarding an absence, the decision to excuse it would rest solely at the discretion of Professor Chen.

Late Policy

Timeliness is crucial in this course, as it reflects your ability to manage deadlines effectively. To accommodate unforeseen circumstances, you are allowed one free late day (24 hours) for any assignment without penalty. This means you can submit an assignment up to 24 hours after the original due date without any impact on your grade.

Beyond the first late day, each additional 24-hour period that the assignment is late will result in a reduction of one letter grade from your final grade for that assignment. For example, if an assignment is due on Monday and you submit it on Wednesday (48 hours late), your grade will drop by two letter grades.

Important Notes:

- The free late day cannot be split across multiple RitW assignments; it applies to a single RitW assignment only.
- If you anticipate any issues that might prevent you from submitting an assignment on time, you must contact Professor Chen no later than the assignment deadline. Requests made after the due time will be declined.
- Assignments submitted more than four days late (96 hours) will automatically receive a grade of zero, unless prior arrangements have been made.

Contact Info

Email is the best way to reach me. If I do not respond to your email after 48 hours, send me a reminder. Please include MC 3505 in the subject line so I can be sure to prioritize your emails.

If you have questions about reading material, lecture content, RitW assignments, or quizzes, I encourage you to talk with other students, come to office hours, and make an appointment with me.

For class-related communication, I will use the mass mail function in Moodle to contact you. Be sure to read Moodle communication.

Professional Communication

All email communication should be written in a professional and respectful tone. Emails written in an informal, text-message style or lacking an appropriate greeting and tone may not receive a response.

LSU Student Code of Conduct

The LSU student code of conduct explains student rights and what is expected of student behavior. Students are expected to understand this code as described on the [Code of Conduct page](#). Any violations of the LSU student code will be duly reported to the Dean of Students.

Disabilities

The University is committed to making reasonable efforts to assist individuals with disabilities in their efforts to avail themselves of services and programs offered by the University. To this end, Louisiana State University will provide reasonable accommodations for persons with documented qualifying disabilities. If you have a disability and feel you need accommodations in this course, you must present a letter to me from Disability Services in 124 Johnston Hall, indicating the existence of a disability and the suggested accommodations.

Permissible Use of Generative AI

As a partner in your learning, it is important to both of us that any assignment submission is a pure reflection of your work and understanding. In this course, using AI programs such as ChatGPT is permitted for the purposes of enhancing your understanding of course materials, encouraging creative exploration and supporting academic growth. These programs should not be used to produce work that misrepresents your abilities or deceives as to the conditions under which the work was completed.

If you choose to utilize AI programs to generate content, you must clearly acknowledge the use of AI-generated material. Proper attribution of AI program use should include an explanation of how the program contributed to the assignment and/or your academic growth. Failing to give proper attribution to the use of AI programs in academic work will be reported to Student Advocacy & Accountability for review under the Code of Student Conduct and may result in impacts to your assignment and/or course grades.

Academic Success

The primary ingredients of your academic success are attending class, managing your time efficiently, taking good notes, and developing good critical thinking and communication abilities. LSU has a number of excellent resources that will assist you in developing these skills. The place to begin is the **Center for Academic Success** (CAS). The CAS offers guidance on what learning strategies are best suited to your talents, tutoring in the basic subjects, and workshops on a variety of topics, from note-taking to time management. **Communication Across the Curriculum** assist students in developing the communication skills necessary for academic and professional success. Finally, with respect to professional success, the **LSU Olinde Career Center** can assist you in choosing a major and a profession that best suits your talents and passions and help you develop a four-year career plan to ensure success when you graduate from LSU.

Nondiscrimination, Sexual Harassment, & Title IX

LSU provides equal opportunity for all qualified persons in admission to, participation in, or employment in the programs and activities which the university operates without regard to race, creed, color, marital status, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, religion, sex, national origin, age, mental or physical disability, or veteran's status. LSU has implemented a procedure to address complaints for those who believe they have been subjected to discrimination and/or harassment in violation of this policy. Please know that your instructors are here to support you and listen to your experience. We also want you to know that we are mandatory reporters and must report what we know to the Office of Civil Rights and Title IX. All LSU employees, with few exceptions, are required to report instances of sex- or gender-based harassment and discrimination, including sexual misconduct and power-based violence (e.g., sexual assault, stalking, dating violence, domestic violence, sexual exploitation, retaliation, etc.) for which they may not be the victim, but of which they are aware. The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is the LSU office responsible for investigating complaints regarding any type of discrimination, sexual harassment, or power-based violence. The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is located in 118 Himes Hall and the phone number is 225-578-9000. If you are aware of an individual who has been victimized, you are encouraged to contact the Office of Civil Rights & Title IX or file an online report by visiting **LSU's Title IX** website and clicking the **Report an Incident** box. If you have been assaulted, harassed, or a victim of violence, we encourage you to contact the Office of Civil Rights & Title IX. Please reach out for help immediately. Some excellent resources available to Baton Rouge residents include:

- STAR (Sexual Trauma Awareness and Response; 24/7 hotline: 855-435-STAR (7827)
- IRIS Domestic Violence Center; 24/7 hotline: 800-541-9706
- The Lighthouse Program; 225-578-5718
- VIA LINK; 800-273-TALK (8255) [national line but answered from New Orleans]

National resources include:

- RAINN (Rape, Abuse & Incest National Network); 24/7 hotline: 800-656-4673
- National Sexual Violence Resource Center

For additional information, visit www.lsu.edu/civil-rights the **Office of Civil Rights & Title IX** and review **PM-73** (Prohibiting Power-based Violence, including Sex- and Gender-based Harassment and Discrimination, and Sexual Misconduct).

LSU Collegiate Recovery Program

Louisiana State University is committed to being inclusive to students in recovery, and to assisting students who are exploring recovery resources. LSU's Collegiate Recovery Program is geared toward helping students remain in recovery while at LSU and seeks to advocate for students' recovery when applicable. If you have questions about LSU's Collegiate Recovery Program or available resources, please call 225-578-4826 or email asinge6@lsu.edu.

Wellbeing

Your sense of wellbeing is influenced by many parts of your life. The extent to which you feel happy, healthy and otherwise fulfilled matters to us at LSU. Should you need direction to address any number of problems you may have that is directly influencing your sense of wellbeing, please visit lsu.edu/lsucares or complete the **LSU wellbeing resources and support form** to inquire as to specific offices to address your concerns. Please note the form is for non-emergency matters. For those matters requiring immediate attention, call the LSU police at 225-578-3231 or LSU Cares at 225-578-4307. For free, confidential, 24/7 emotional support and crisis management, call or text The Phone at 225-924-5781 (LSU1) or the Lifeline at 988.

Remote Learning

In the event of a campus-wide closure, this course may transition to an alternative form of instruction. I will notify you by Moodle announcement as soon as possible of the format our course will take. For example, the class may be held via Zoom and recorded for those unable to attend, or I will provide a lesson online that you can do asynchronously, or we may cover content at a different pace or schedule. If the emergency closure impacts scheduled tests, I will make alternative arrangements as soon as possible. If alternative formats are not available due to widespread loss of power and/or internet or other extenuating circumstances, the University may schedule makeup days per **Policy Statement 117**.

Grade Review

I do not discuss grades over email. I am willing to review written requests for grade review submitted no earlier than one week after the grade is released and no later than four weeks following the grade release. In your written request, please explain the reasons you believe a regrade is warranted. If such a request is made, students must be prepared that a review may result in either a lower or higher grade.